



UNITED NATIONS ECONOMIC AND SOCIAL COUNCIL (ECOSOC)

Background Paper

Topic:

The Socio-Economic Impact of Climate Change and the Accelerating Extinction of Glaciers

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I. The United Nations Economic and Social Council: History and Powers

The United Nations Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC) is one of the six principal organs of the United Nations, established in 1945 under the UN Charter.

Historical Background

ECOSOC was created to coordinate international economic, social, and environmental cooperation. It serves as the central platform within the UN system for discussing sustainable development and global socio-economic challenges.

The Council consists of 54 Member States elected by the General Assembly for three-year terms, ensuring equitable geographic representation.

Over time, ECOSOC has played a crucial role in:

- Promoting sustainable development
- Coordinating UN specialized agencies
- Advancing global economic stability
- Addressing climate-related development challenges

Powers and Functions

ECOSOC has the authority to:

- Conduct studies and issue policy recommendations
- Coordinate UN agencies such as the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP)
- Oversee functional commissions on sustainable development
- Promote implementation of the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs)

While ECOSOC resolutions are not legally binding, they significantly influence global economic and environmental policy frameworks.

II. Introduction to the Topic

Glaciers are critical components of the Earth's climate system. They regulate freshwater supply, contribute to sea-level stability, and support ecosystems and economies worldwide.

However, climate change has dramatically accelerated glacier melting in regions such as:

- Himalayas
- Andes
- Alps
- Greenland

The rapid extinction of glaciers poses severe socio-economic consequences, particularly for communities dependent on glacial meltwater for agriculture, drinking water, and energy production.

III. Scientific and Historical Background

Since the late 19th century, global temperatures have risen significantly due to greenhouse gas emissions. Reports by the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) confirm that glaciers worldwide are retreating at unprecedented rates.

Key impacts include:

- Rising sea levels
- Increased flooding and glacial lake outburst floods (GLOFs)
- Reduced freshwater availability
- Disruption of hydropower systems
- Loss of tourism-based economies

For example:

- Melting in the Himalayas threatens water supplies for over a billion people.
- Andean glacier retreat impacts agriculture in Peru and Bolivia.
- Arctic ice loss accelerates global warming through reduced albedo effect.

IV. Socio-Economic Impacts

The extinction of glaciers directly affects:

1. Water Security

Communities relying on glacial melt face long-term shortages.

2. Agriculture

Irrigation systems in Asia and South America depend on seasonal meltwater.

3. Energy Production

Hydropower generation declines as water flows become unpredictable.

4. Coastal Economies

Sea-level rise threatens infrastructure, tourism, and fisheries.

5. Migration

Environmental degradation may lead to climate-induced displacement.

These impacts disproportionately affect developing nations with limited adaptive capacity.

V. International Framework

Relevant frameworks include:

- The Paris Agreement
- The Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), especially:
 - SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation
 - SDG 8: Decent Work and Economic Growth
 - SDG 13: Climate Action

Despite these frameworks, adaptation funding remains insufficient, and vulnerable states continue to face economic losses.

VI. Current Situation (2026 Context)

As of 2026:

- Glacier mass loss continues to accelerate.
- Extreme weather events are increasing in frequency.
- Developing nations demand stronger climate financing.
- Discussions on Loss and Damage funding remain central in global negotiations.

The issue requires coordinated economic policy, climate adaptation funding, and sustainable development planning.

VII. Key Questions for Debate

Delegates should consider:

1. How can ECOSOC support glacier-dependent economies?
2. Should international climate finance be expanded?
3. How can water security be ensured in vulnerable regions?
4. What economic transition strategies can support affected communities?
5. How can global cooperation prevent further glacial loss?

VIII. Conclusion

The accelerating extinction of glaciers is not only an environmental crisis but a profound socio-economic challenge.

ECOSOC plays a vital role in:

- Promoting sustainable development
- Coordinating economic adaptation strategies
- Mobilizing climate finance
- Protecting vulnerable populations

Delegates must develop policies that integrate environmental science with economic resilience to ensure long-term global stability.

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